

**Unit 1, Option B,
Topic B3: The
Revolt of the
Netherlands, 1559-
1609**

The main focus of this topic is on the causes of the Netherlands Revolt and on the reasons for its partial success by 1609. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which focus exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The bullet points should not be considered in isolation. Collectively, they offer a framework for understanding the key themes of why the Netherlands rebelled and why and how some of the provinces gained independence from Spanish rule. Students should be aware of the links and interaction between the bullet points. For example, understanding of the causes of the revolt relates to underlying problems (bullet 1), the role of William the Silent (bullet 2) and the mistakes and misjudgements made by the Spanish authorities (bullet 3).

The first bullet point in the specification relates to the underlying causes of the revolt. These include the impact of Calvinism in the Netherlands, the structure of authority at the time and the rule of the Spanish under Margaret of Parma and the Duke of Alba. Questions will not be set which require knowledge of the political and religious situation in the Netherlands before 1559 but contextual knowledge of wider political and religious conflicts in Europe can be useful. Students should be aware of the extent to which Spanish handling of the situation increased the likelihood and extent of revolt. This can be exemplified by considering individuals such as Philip II and Alba.

The second bullet point, 'the House of Orange', relates to the roles of William the Silent and Maurice of Nassau and their contribution to the success of the revolt and to creating a sense of national identity. Students should understand the significance of the House of Orange within the government of the provinces, William's role as an early leader, and the significance of his assassination. They should also have knowledge of the emergence of Maurice, the quality of his military leadership, his relations with other factions and individuals such as Oldenbarnevelt, and his role in achieving independence by 1609.